



Scale Choices — what to play over what

UNDERCOVER ZEST

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The working answers, not the theory lecture. Degrees relative to each chord's own root.

BLUES (KEY OF A USED IN EXAMPLES)

OVER	PLAY	NOTES
Whole blues, down-home	A minor pentatonic + b5	one scale over everything; band makes the tension
I7 chord (A7)	A major pentatonic lean	sweetness at home; mix with minor pent freely
IV7 / V7 (D7, E7)	A minor pentatonic lean	grit when you leave home
Uptown / jazz-blues	chord tones: land each 3rd	C# over A7, F# over D7, G# over E7
Minor blues	A natural minor / dorian	dorian (raised 6) over the iv chord sounds modern

JAZZ — CHORD-BY-CHORD (THE 90% ANSWERS)

OVER	PLAY	NOTES
maj7 (Cmaj7)	major scale (ionian)	or lydian (#4) when it is the IV chord
m7 (Dm7)	dorian	minor with a raised 6 — the default jazz minor
7 (G7)	mixolydian	major with a b7; add the b9/#9 colours later
m7b5 (Dm7b5)	locrian	or locrian natural-2 for a friendlier sound
dim7	whole-half diminished	symmetrical; every minor 3rd transposition works
7alt (G7alt)	altered scale	melodic minor a half-step up (Ab mel. minor over G7)

THE HONEST SHORTCUTS

- Guide tones beat scales: the 3rd and 7th of each chord, connected by step, outline everything.
- Over a whole ii-V-I, the I chord's major scale already contains all three chords' notes.
- Blues scale over jazz blues always works at a jam. Taste comes later.
- When lost: play the melody. Nobody ever complained.